

4 October 2011

Melbourne, inner-city cafe

I could tell from the moment she walked in that she didn't want to be there.

I was having coffee with an old colleague of mine—a man I'll call Bill.

Bill had brought along his sixteen-year-old daughter—who I'll call Emma.

As they sat down Bill mumbled something about it being school holidays and then added:

'I want her to learn something from you.'

Emma wore thick makeup, a tank top and dark sunnies that made it impossible to make eye contact.

She half-smiled, slumped into her chair, and began texting on her phone.

Bill said, 'Emma needs your help, doncha honey?'

Emma looked up and, with her best selfie pout, said: 'Apparently you're going to teach me about money.'

'What would you like to know?' I asked.

She shrugged her shoulders, and then looked back down at her phone.

'She has zero interest in money,' Bill offered.

Now Bill is a smart, loving, committed father. Over the years he'd risen up the chain in financial services to where he was pulling in decent dough. And over those years he'd spent a fair chunk of his money making sure his family had a good life.

Emma attended one of the best private schools in Melbourne, which had been hoovering up Bill's cash for the past decade. The whole family went on holidays overseas most years. They lived in a comfortable home, in a nice suburb, with good neighbours.

Bill and his wife had tried the chore routine a few times, but it never lasted more than a couple of weeks. And Emma was now protesting that she couldn't get a part-time job because she was too focused on her studies, given that she was heading into her final school years.